

23. A pause of fifteen years gave certainly every opportunity for completing such arrangements as were necessary for the defence of the town. It may be thought that even the territory might have been secured against hostile invasion, if a proper strategic use had been made of the natural barriers furnished by the two broad and deep rivers, and the artificial obstructions, consisting of canals, dykes, and embankments with which the whole country was covered. The preservation of the capital, however, seems to have been all that was attempted. This is evidenced by the nature of the defences constructed at this period, and still more by the care taken to provision the city for a siege. It was probably hoped that the enormous height and thickness of the walls would baffle all attempts to force an entrance on the part of the besiegers, and that the quantity of corn laid up in store, and the extent of land within the defences on which fresh crops might be raised,⁷ would render reduction by blockade impracticable. The whole mass of the population of the country might easily take shelter within the space enclosed by the great walls; and so Babylon, like Athens in the Peloponnesian war, intended to surrender its territory to the enemy to be ravaged at pleasure, and to concentrate all efforts on the defence of the metropolis. When Cyrus, at the end of the fifteen years, appeared before the walls, a single battle was fought, to try whether it was necessary to submit to a siege at all; and when the victory declared for the Persians, the Babylonians very contentedly retired within their defences, and thought to defy their enemy.* Thenceforth "the mighty men of Babylon forebore to fight—they remained in their holds."⁸ We are not informed how long the siege lasted, but no second effort seems to have been made to drive away the assailants.

24. After a time Cyrus put in execution the stratagem, which (it may be conjectured) he had resolved to practise before he left Agbatana. By the dispersion of the waters of the Gyndes,¹ his army had perhaps gained an experience which it was important for them to acquire before attempting to deal with the far mightier stream of the Euphrates, where any accident—the weakness of a floodgate, or the disruption of a dyke—might not only have disconcerted the scheme on which the taking of Babylon depended, but have destroyed a large portion of the Persian army. The exact mode by which Cyrus drained the stream of its water is uncertain. Herodotus relates that it was by turning the river into

⁷ It must be borne in mind that the walls of Babylon, like those of most Oriental towns, enclosed rather populous districts than cities. It is quite impossible that a tract containing above 130 square miles should have been one-half covered with houses. On the other hand, it is highly probable that as much as nine-tenths may have consisted of gardens, parks, *paradises*, and even mere fields and orchards. (Compare Q. Curt. v. 1, § 27.) During a siege the whole of this could be used for growing corn. Hence the confidence of the Babylonians (λόγον εἶχον τῆς πολιουρίας οὐδένα).

⁸ Herod. i. 190. Berosus agreed in speaking of a single battle (ap. Joseph. contr. Ap. l. s. c.).

⁹ Jer. li. 30.

¹ The Gyndes is identified, almost to a certainty, with the Diyálah, by the fact that it was crossed by boats on the road between Sardis and Susa after the Greater and the Lesser Zab (Herod. v. 52.) The Diyálah is the only stream of this magnitude between the Lesser Zab and the Kerkhah (Choaspes), on which Susa stood.

the receptacle excavated by Nitocris, when she made the stone piers of the bridge within the town.² Xenophon records a tradition that it was by means of two new cuttings of his own, from a point of the river above the city to a point below it.³ Both agree that he entered the city by the channel of the Euphrates, and that he waited for a general festival which was likely to engage the attention of the inhabitants, before turning the stream from its natural bed.⁴ If the sinking of the water had been observed, his plan would have been frustrated by the closing of the city water-gates, and his army would have been caught, as Herodotus expresses it, "in a trap."⁵

25. The city was taken at the extremities long ere the inhabitants of the central parts had a suspicion of their danger. Then it may well be that "one post ran to meet another, and one messenger to meet another, to show the king of Babylon that his city was taken at one end."⁶ According to Berosus, indeed, Nabonadius was not in Babylon, but at Borsippa, at the time when Babylon was taken, having fled to that comparatively unimportant city when his army was defeated in the field.⁷ He seems, however, to have left in Babylon a representative in the person of his son, whom a few years previously he had associated with him in the government. This prince, whose name is read as *Bil-shar-uzur*, and who may be identified with the Belshazzar of Daniel,⁸ appears to have taken the command in the city when Nabonadius threw himself, for some unexplained reason, into Borsippa, which was undoubtedly a strong fortress, and was also one of the chief seats of Chaldæan learning,⁹ but which assuredly could not compare, either for magnificence or for strength, with Babylon. Belshazzar, who was probably a mere youth, left to enjoy the supreme power without check or control, neglected the

² Herod. i. 191.

³ Xen. Cyrop. vii. v. 10.

⁴ Herod. l. s. c.; Xen. Cyrop. vii. v. 15.

⁵ *Ὡς ἐν κύρτῃ.*

⁶ Jer. li. 31.

⁷ *Ναβόννηδος ἡττηθεὶς τῇ μάχῃ συνεκλείσθη εἰς τὴν Βορσιππητὴν πόλιν* (ap. Joseph. contr. Ap. i. 21).

⁸ Ch. v. Two difficulties still stand in the way of this identification, which (if accepted) solves one of the most intricate problems of ancient history. The first is the relationship in which the Belshazzar of Scripture stands to Nebuchadnezzar, which is throughout represented as that of son (verses 2, 11, 13, 18, &c.); the second is the accession, immediately after Belshazzar, of "Darius the Mede." With respect to the first of these, it may be remarked that although Nabonadius was not a descendant, or indeed any relation, of Nebuchadnezzar, Belshazzar may have been, and very probably was. Nabu-nahit, on seizing the supreme power, would naturally seek to strengthen his position by marriage with a daughter of the great king, whose son, son-in-law, and grandson had successively held the throne. He may have taken to wife Neriglissar's widow, or he may have married some other daughter of Nebuchadnezzar. Belshazzar may thus have been grandson of Nebuchadnezzar *on the mother's side*. It is some confirmation of these probabilities, or possibilities, to find that the name of Nebuchadnezzar was used as a family name by Nabu-nahit. He must certainly have had a son to whom he gave that appellation, or it would not have been assumed by two pretenders in succession, who sought to personate the legitimate heir of the Babylonian throne.

On the difficulty presented by the reign of Darius the Mede in Babylon, some remarks have already been made in the Essay, "On the Great Median Empire" (Essay iii. § 11).

⁹ Strab. xvi. p. 1050. Strabo also says that it was famous for its manufacture of linen.

duty of watching the enemy, and gave himself up to enjoyment. The feast of which we read in Daniel, and which suffered such an awful interruption, may have been in part a religious festivity,¹ but it indicates nevertheless the self-indulgent temper of the king, who could give himself so entirely up to merriment at such a time. While the king and his "thousand nobles"² drank wine out of the sacred vessels of the Jews, the Persian archers entered the city, and a scene of carnage ensued. "In that night was Belshazzar slain."³ Amid the confusion and the darkness, the young prince, probably unrecognised by the soldiery, who would have respected his rank had they perceived it,⁴ was struck down by an unknown hand, and lost his life with his kingdom.

26. Cyrus then, having given orders to ruin the defences of the city,⁵ proceeded to the attack of Borsippa, where Nabonadius still maintained himself. But the loss of his capital and his son had subdued the spirit of the elder prince, and on the approach of the enemy he at once surrendered himself.⁶ Cyrus treated him with the gentleness shown commonly by the Persians to those of royal dignity,⁷ and assigned him a residence and estates in Carmania, forming a sort of principality, which has been magnified into the government of the province.⁸ Here, according to Berosus, he ended his days in peace. Abydenus, however,

¹ See Herod. i. 191. *τυχεῖν γὰρ σφι ἐοῦσαν ὀρτήν*. The religious character of the festival is indicated in the book of Daniel by the words—"They drank wine, and praised the gods of gold, and of silver, of brass, of iron, &c." (verse 4).

² Dan. v. 1.

³ Ibid. verse 30.

⁴ Cræsus nearly lost his life in the same way, amid the confusion consequent upon the taking of his capital by assault, but was spared as soon as his rank was indicated (Herod. i. 85).

⁵ We are generally told, when the capture of Babylon by an enemy is related, that the defences are *demolished*. Berosus said that Cyrus ordered the outer defences to be razed to the ground (*συντράξας τὰ ἔξω τῆς πόλεως τεῖχη κατὰ σκάψαι*, Fr. 14, sub fin.). Herodotus makes Darius *remove* the wall, and tear down the gates, adding that Cyrus had left them standing (*τὸ τεῖχος περιεῖλε, καὶ τὰς πύλας ἀπέσπασε· τὸ γὰρ πρότερον ἔλων Κύρος τὴν Βαβυλῶνα ἐποίησε τούτων οὐδέτερον*, iii. 159). Arrian tells us that Xerxes razed to the ground (*κατέσκαψε*) the temple of Belus (Exp. Alex. vii. 17; compare iii. 16). In every case there is undoubtedly an exaggeration. The conqueror was satisfied to dismantle the city, without engaging in the enormous and useless labour of demolition. He broke, probably, large breaches in the walls, which sufficed to render the place defenceless. When a revolt occurred, these breaches were hastily repaired, and hence Babylon could stand repeated sieges—one at the hand of Cyrus, a second and third during the reign of Darius, and a fourth during that of Xerxes (Ctes. Exc. Pers. § 22). The walls must have remained at least to this last occasion; and certainly Herodotus writes as if he had himself seen them (Herod. i. 178 and 181; see Mr. Grote's note, Hist. of Greece, vol. iii. pp. 395–8). Ctesias too appears to have represented himself as an eye-witness of their grandeur (cf. Diod. Sic. ii. 7. *τὸ ὕψος ἀπίστον τοῖς ἀκούουσιν, ὥς φησι Κτησίας ὁ Κνίδιος*). Abydenus, it must be remembered, expressly declared that the wall of Nebuchadnezzar continued to the Macedonian conquest (see above, page 412, note ¹), and St. Jerome says that the old walls of Babylon had been repaired and served as the enclosure of a park in his day (Comment on Esaiam. xiv. vol. iii. p. 115).

⁶ Beros. Fr. 14 sub fin.

⁷ See Herod. iii. 15, and note ad loc.

⁸ Berosus only said—*χρησάμενος Κύρος φιλανθρώπως (τὸν Ναβόννηδον), καὶ δοὺς οἰκητήριον αὐτῷ Καρμανίαν, ἐξέπεμψε ἐκ τῆς Βαβυλωνίας*. But Abydenus declared—*τὸν δὲ (Ναβαννίδοχον) Κύρος ἔλων Βαβυλῶνα, Καρμανίης ἡγεμονίᾳ δωρέεται* (Fr. 9).

states that he gave offence to Darius, who deprived him of his possessions, and forced him to quit Carmania.⁹

27. It is possible that Nabonadius was involved in one of those revolts of Babylon from Darius, where his name was certainly made use of to stir the people to rebellion, and so incurred the displeasure of the Great King. Twice at least in the reign of that monarch a claimant to the Babylonian crown came forward with the declaration, "I am Nebuchadnezzar, the son of Nabonadius," and each time the magic of the name was sufficient to seduce the Babylonians from their allegiance. Babylon stood two sieges, one at the hands of Darius himself, the other at the hands of one of his generals. On the first occasion two great battles were fought, at the passage of the Tigris, and at Zazana on the Euphrates,¹ Babylon thus offering a stouter resistance to the Persian arms under the leadership of the pretended son of Nabonadius, than it had formerly offered under Nabonadius himself. The siege which followed these battles is probably that which Herodotus intended to describe in the concluding chapters of his third Book; but very little historical authority can be considered to attach to the details of his description.²

Whatever ravages were inflicted on the walls and public buildings of Babylon by the violence of the Persian monarchs, or the slow operation of time, there is reason to believe that it remained the second city in the Persian empire down to the time of the conquest by Alexander. The Persian court resided for the larger portion of the year at the great Mesopotamian capital;³ and when Alexander overran the whole territory of the Achæmenian kings it appears to have attracted a far larger share of his regard than any other city.⁴ Had he lived, it was his intention that Babylon should be restored to all her ancient splendour, and become the metropolis of his wide-spread empire. This intention was frustrated by his death, and the disputes among his successors transferred the seat of government, even for the kingdom of the Seleucidæ, into Syria. From this time Babylon rapidly declined. Seleucia upon the Tigris, which arose in its vicinity, drew away its population,⁵ and the very materials of the ancient Chaldæan capital were gradually removed and used in the construction of a new and rival city. Babylon shortly "became heaps,"⁶ and realised the descriptions of prophecy.⁷ The or-

⁹ Ap. Euseb. Chron. Can. pars I. c. x.

¹ Behist. Inscr. Col. I. Par. 16-19; Col. II. Par. 1.; Col. III. Par. 13-4.

² The Behistun Inscription is conclusive, as far as negative evidence can be, against the details of the siege given in Herodotus. After a careful and elaborate account, contained in two entire paragraphs, of the war which preceded the siege, we hear simply, "Then Naditabirus, with the horsemen, his well-wishers, fled to Babylon. *I both took Babylon and seized that Naditabirus*" (Col. II. Par. 1). The details cannot belong to the second siege, in the reign of Darius, since the city was not then taken by Darius in person, but by Intaphres (Col. III. par. 14). It is probable, therefore, that if any such circumstances as those related by Herodotus ever took place, it was, as Ctesias asserted, on occasion of the revolt from Xerxes. Col. Rawlinson sees reason to doubt the whole tale. (Note on the Beh. Inscript. p. xvi.)

³ See Brisson. de Regn. Pers. i. pp. 58-9.

⁴ Cf. Arrian. Exped. Alex. vii. 17, 19, 21; Strab. xvi. p. 1049.

⁵ Plin. H. N. vi. 30.

⁶ Jer. li. 37.

⁷ Isa. xiii. 19-22: "And Babylon, the glory of kingdoms, the beauty of the